

Cover story **TIGER POACHING**

to poach tigers to supply them to organised smugglers in tiger parts who feed the market in China. They commit crimes as a family vocation, are cunning, constantly on the move, and kill tigers with religious fervour. Killing a tiger means big money, Rs 2 lakh for a tiger skin, and being adept hunters, it also means easy money, tiger parts and organs fetch another Rs 2 lakh. What is less known about these tribes is that they indulge in other criminal activities. They also kill leopards, bears and elephants for ivory, indulge in organised theft of railways and telecom properties, are into sandalwood smuggling while some do contractual murders. Being nomadic, they cannot be traced for their crimes. Their latest racket is land scams, and Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi would be shocked to know that the men and women who are killing tigers in the state's reserves are also part of a gigantic compensation scam for the Narmada Valley Project.

Pardhis have migrated en-mass from various villages in Katni district of Madhya Pradesh, a Mecca for poachers, down to Khandwa and Harda districts along the Maharashtra border to seek compensation as displaced families from the Narmada Valley Project. Some of them have actually got lakhs of rupees as compensation along with land, while others are camping there for their share of the booty. Locals know about it but are too scared to talk. Local officials do nothing presumably because they are getting a cut. If tigers are to be saved in the forests of India, this vicious network and nexus of tribals and traders will have to be broken.

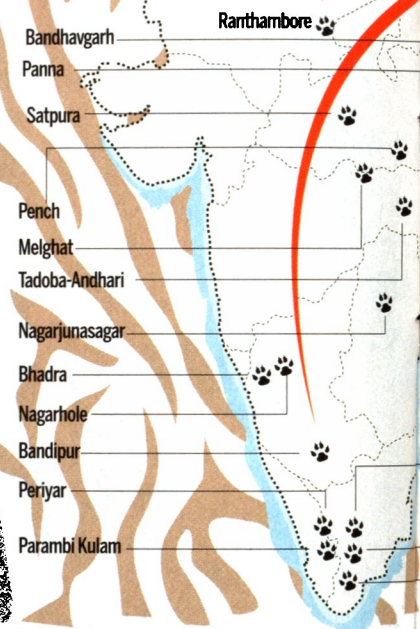
It is now clear that tigers and tribals cannot live together in a forest, as was the case traditionally, for the lure of big money is impossible to resist.

The poachers are hired and sent into the forests by notorious traders like Sansar Chand and Shabeer Hassan Qureshi. Both are currently in jail and together would be responsible for 1,000 tiger deaths in the last decade but now their extended families are carrying on with tiger killings. It's a tightly knit nexus: traditional hunting families supply tiger parts to traditional families trading in wild animals. Poachers-turned-informers and some Pardhis themselves revealed the modus operandi and rewards.

Here's how the unholy nexus works—and spells doom for the tiger. The tribal hunters receive orders, estimated to be for 60 tigers a year, to be skinned and body parts collected and preserved. The hunting party, including women and children, sets off by train to the target zone. Reaching the targeted forest, they camp in the vicinity, setting up temporary shops selling cheap jewellery as a cover. It takes them just a few days to learn about tiger movements in the area. They lay

Big Cat Under Threat

Poachers and organised smugglers supply tiger parts to Tibet via Nepal



Graphic by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY/www.indiatodayimages.com

SANSAR CHAND AND SHABEER HASSAN QURESHI ARE TOGETHER RESPONSIBLE FOR THE ESTIMATED KILLING OF 1,000 TIGERS.

Market for Tiger Parts



Skin ▲
\$20,000-25,000
Used for display and to treat mental illness.

Brain
\$2,000
Used to treat laziness and pimples.

Nose Leather
\$500
Used to treat superficial wounds and minor bites.

Bones ▼
\$500/kg
Treats rheumatism, arthritis, general



weakness, headaches, stiffness or paralysis in lower back and legs and dysentery.

Whiskers ►
\$100
Used to treat toothache.

Photographs courtesy: EIA

